This flavorful soup needs no accompaniment, but croûtes rubbed with garlic, spread with rouille (see p234), or topped with Gruyère cheese are a welcome addition.

soupe de poissons

SERVES 6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 1 HOUR **FREEZE** UP TO 2 MONTHS

5 tbsp olive oil
4 medium onions, chopped
2 leeks, chopped
3lb 3oz–4½lb (1½–2kg) mixed fish and seafood
4 pieces dried fennel stalks, 2in (5cm) long
4 medium, ripe tomatoes, quartered
9 garlic cloves, crushed
5 sprigs of fresh flat-leaf parsley
3 bay leaves
6in (15cm) strip dried orange peel
1 tbsp tomato purée
salt and freshly ground black pepper
pinch of saffron threads
6 croûtes, to serve

1 Put the oil in a large, heavy saucepan. Add the onions and leeks and soften over medium heat until just golden.

2 Gut the larger fish, and rinse all the fish and seafood. Add to the pan and stir, then add the fennel, tomatoes, garlic, parsley, bay leaves, orange peel, and tomato purée. Stir and cook for 8–10 minutes until the fish is just beginning to flake when pierced with a fork. Pour in 2½ quarts (2½ liters) hot water and season lightly with salt and pepper. Reduce the heat and simmer gently for 20 minutes.

3 Remove from the heat. Let cool a little, stirring and mashing down the soft fish pieces with the back of a large wooden spoon. Remove the fennel, orange peel, and bay leaves. If you like, process the soup to a coarse purée in a blender. Push the soup through a chinois or a very fine sieve into a clean saucepan. Return the soup to a simmer over medium heat.

4 Soften the saffron in a ladleful of the soup, then stir into the rest of the soup in the pan. Adjust the seasoning. Ladle the soup into bowls. Serve hot, with croûtes.